Folk Songs of The Tangkhul

TITLE: Folk Songs of The Tangkhul
Identifier: BK-LIT-002
Level: Community / Cultural | Subject: Ethnomusicology and Oral Lore
Publisher: Directorate for Development of Tribals & Backward Classes, Manipur (1987)
Language: Tangkhul (Standard Tangkhul)
Preservation Archive: Tangkhul Language Library Digital Repository

---

Preface & Archival Information

Folk Songs of The Tangkhul compiled by Dr. H. Kamkhenthang (Senior Research Officer) and A. Ngashan Chahong (Secretary, Tangkhul Hao Art & Cultural Council, Ukhrul), published by the Directorate for Development of Tribals and Backward Classes, Manipur (1987). Presents 27 representative genres of Tangkhul folk music with vernacular lyrics and parallel English translations.

Table of Contents

TABLE OF CONTENTS:

Front Cover & Title Page (p. 1)
Imprint, Archival Rights & Preface (p. 2)
Table of Contents (p. 3)
Chapter 1: Invocations & Spring Songs (Zingkum Hao Kaphok) (pp. 4-5)
Chapter 2: Tarung Carrying & Monument Construction Songs (pp. 6-7)
Chapter 3: Ceremonial Dance & Hornbill Movements (Pheishon Laa) (pp. 8-9)
Chapter 4: Maiden Dances & Youth Festivals (Yarra Laa) (pp. 10-11)
Chapter 5: Agriculture, Terrace Labor & Cowherd Songs (pp. 12-13)
Chapter 6: Martial Ballads & Head-hunting Epics (Ral Laa) (pp. 14-15)
Chapter 7: Traditional Love Romances (Shimreishang & Maitonphi) (pp. 16-18)
Chapter 8: Weaving Songs, Festive Banquets & Bedtime Chants (pp. 19-20)
Comprehensive Glossary & Vocabulary Index (p. 21)
Back Cover & Archival Colophon (p. 22)

Chapter 1: Invocations & Spring Songs (Zingkum Hao Kaphok)

CHAPTER 1: INVOCATIONS & SPRING SONGS (ZINGKUM HAO KAPHOK)

Summary: Hokharai war-cry and spring arrival songs heralded by Sampheirok and Koktui.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

AE-HE! Phamei yameisa HE... HE. O--O-HU-O! Ilongnao laa sa usa, Kashishoklu, kaphazanglu--O--Hui-O-hui! O, kazingkum ura, o, kazingkum ura, o, hungnaovayo luithuimihaolu; Mamanaomara, hungnaovayo luithuimashunga; Sampheirokna riri rakhonga, koktui vana zingkum phungraya!

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Hokharai invocation: May the better be ours! Let us sing, may evil depart and divine goodness enter! O, spring has begun! Your highness, sow the seeds for the year; royal venture is just and timely; The Sampheirok sings melodiously and the cuckoo heralds the arrival of the fruitful year!

Chapter 1 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 1 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* hokharai (noun): invocation shout
  Example: Hokharai invocation.
* kazingkum (noun): spring season
  Example: Kazingkum ura.
* sampheirok (noun): spring songbird
  Example: Sampheirokna rakhonga.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Ritual invocation phonetics.
- Reduplication in bird call onomatopoeia ('riri rakhonga').

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? What is Hokharai and when is it performed?
? Which birds announce the arrival of spring?

Chapter 2: Tarung Carrying & Monument Construction Songs

CHAPTER 2: TARUNG CARRYING & MONUMENT CONSTRUCTION SONGS

Summary: Dragging the monumental Tarung tree from the forest and erecting megaliths.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

O, yarso thingrei vakhang, thingpitang tak ungrall yaronnao, thingreiva ungreilu! Seichang kharaei hangmi phalungra, phanora vashatta chaklen meikan naona kacheka, lumlao sakda vakhuiphalungra. O, Kashongta phung-o, maranla saya; ilangkaso machilo, I wui luiyi kaya lhuiito, I wui chumrei hjorphiya!

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

O young men, lift the mighty tree! The twigs bend, pull together with sturdy cane ropes; The sacrificial mithun is provided, the augury bird Chaklen gave favorable omens; carry home the Tarung! I built this house from humble beginnings; my terrace fields are fertile and granary full!

Chapter 2 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 2 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* thingreikhangava (noun): carrying the monument tree
  Example: Thingreiva ungreilu.
* chaklen (noun): augury bird
  Example: Chaklen kacheka.
* chumrei (noun): grain barn
  Example: Chumrei hjorphiya.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Collective working rhythm in dragging chants.
- Augury interpretation terminology.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? What bird’s call determines the auspiciousness of monument hauling?

? What animal is sacrificed for the Tarung?

Chapter 3: Ceremonial Dance & Hornbill Movements (Pheishon Laa)

CHAPTER 3: CEREMONIAL DANCE & HORNBILL MOVEMENTS (PHEISHON LAA)

Summary: Dance steps modeled on the flight and wingbeats of the great Indian hornbill.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

O, iram hongreili, Mafathing kasui kharipna; Ngachamching arang shangkaya, arangchi khili kachanlo? Mafathei channa, arangkho arangkhon ngashing leishiya; Thuingashing, kashung shanghaowa.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

In our ancient forests, the majestic Mafathing trees spread their wide canopy; Upon their boughs perch the great hornbills; why have they gathered in numbers? For the ripe Mafa fruits they have flown; with rhythmic wingbeats they soar towards the mountain peaks!

Chapter 3 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 3 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* pheishon (noun): ceremonial hornbill dance
  Example: Pheishon laa.
* arang (noun): hornbill
  Example: Arang shangkaya.
* mafathing (noun): Phoebe hainesiana timber tree
  Example: Mafathing kasui.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Choreographic terminology encoded in song lyrics.
- Rhythmic meter imitating animal locomotion.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? What bird inspires the choreography of Pheishon?

? Why is the hornbill culturally sacred to Tangkhuls?

Chapter 4: Maiden Dances & Youth Festivals (Yarra Laa)

CHAPTER 4: MAIDEN DANCES & YOUTH FESTIVALS (YARRA LAA)

Summary: Laa Khanganui maiden dances and the Yarra spring festival of the youth.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Kazingkum huimailo aria, shivanaoli khina sale? Kha shingnai rao vasaya,
he ring khaya zak matheiya. Kongrali theo theo, ilongnaova khithing
kaphato? Ilongnaova longthing kaphana, meishum kapamnao zangyo!

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Let the seasons turn in gentleness! Maidens dance in the village square
in graceful innocence. What merry voices echo by the stream? The youth
gather firewood for the annual Yarra celebration!

Chapter 4 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 4 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* yarra laa (noun): youth festival song
  Example: Yarra laa sa.
* longthing (noun): communal firewood
  Example: Longthing kaphana.
* meishum (noun): morung fireplace
  Example: Meishum kapamnao.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Youth-group terminology.
- Onomatopoeic stream sounds 'theo theo'.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? In which months is the Yarra festival celebrated?

? What activity do the youth undertake during Yarra?

Chapter 5: Agriculture, Terrace Labor & Cowherd Songs

CHAPTER 5: AGRICULTURE, TERRACE LABOR & COWHERD SONGS

Summary: Luisom paddy planting chants and Sei Hom cowherd ballads of solitary orphans.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

O, I siluisa, I siluisa khinashai? I makreira khina mang, makreira sangralu; Shama maran saluira. Ava khaho malei, aya kaho malei, seihom langphaizaya; Shok reo rangpamshona, silui shur khani chi kachui laga yaronnao chara horlama.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Who will feast on my buffalo meat, who will drink my aged rice beer? Pour generously for the laborers! No parents call my name; upon the high grassy slopes I herd buffalos alone from dawn till dusk, Tending the herds while silent tears trace lines upon my face.

Chapter 5 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 5 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* siluisa (noun): buffalo meat for terrace workers
  Example: I siluisa khinashai.
* seihom (noun): cattle herding
  Example: Seihom langphaizaya.
* makreira (noun): fermented rice beverage
  Example: Makreira khina mang.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Rhetorical questions in festive work songs.
- Poignant elegiac tone in pastoral chants.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? What contrast is drawn between festive terrace planting and cowherd life?

? What is 'siluisa'?

Chapter 6: Martial Ballads & Head-hunting Epics (Ral Laa)

CHAPTER 6: MARTIAL BALLADS & HEAD-HUNTING EPICS (RAL LAA)

Summary: Ancient heroic victory chants and warrior prowess of Lunghar and Ringui.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

O, atung shangla rai sakashiyavo, Lunghar yaron ni chiya! Azing takha rai sakashiyavo, Ringui yaron ni chiya! Shangching Shangshak na ili khachitna chiya, shimin kayang ra mahon shok! Kharing sing singa, ili mangakatshelu!

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Behold in the northern heights the gallant warriors of Lunghar stand ready! In the southern ranges the brave youths of Ringui guard the mountain passes; They fear me as the tiger of the forest; challenge me not, for our victory shout resounds!

Chapter 6 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 6 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* ral laa (noun): war song, victory chant
  Example: Ral laa sa.
* kharing (adj): alive, captive
  Example: Kharing sing singa.
* mahon (noun): battle shout
  Example: Mahon shok.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Vocative and boastful declamatory syntax.
- Geographical identifiers of warrior clans.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? Which two villages are celebrated as warrior centres?

? What does 'kharing sing' mean?

Chapter 7: Traditional Love Romances (Shimreishang & Maitonphi)

CHAPTER 7: TRADITIONAL LOVE ROMANCES (SHIMREISHANG & MAITONPHI)

Summary: The immortal romance of Shimreishang and Maitonphi in antiphonal dialogue.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Avayo avayo, makhamalu, Maitonphili rasha saka; sakhangaiye Maitonphi kharam thuihaowa. Laishikhavai chi lunamlizang ngaroksa; Coi marongthei reola khuisingda lung ringa. Ameishang Ameishang, Ira kachangli thuiulu; Maitonphi, pangthui haosa, ini lungchan malaihaosa.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Elders, do not forbid! For sweet Maitonphi alone does my heart beat in devotion; Though adverse circumstances part us in this earthly life, our love remains green like the mountain pine. Beloved Ameishang, farewell on this mortal shore; in the spirit realm beyond, we shall part no more.

Chapter 7 (Continued)

CHAPTER 7: READING CONTINUATION (PAGE 17)

TANGKHUL TEXT (CONTINUED):

Avayo avayo, makhamalu, Maitonphili rasha saka; sakhangaiye Maitonphi kharam thuihaowa. Laishikhavai chi lunamlizang ngaroksa; Coi marongthei reola khuisingda lung ringa. Ameishang Ameishang, Ira kachangli thuiulu; Maitonphi, pangthui haosa, ini lungchan malaihaosa.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION (CONTINUED):

Elders, do not forbid! For sweet Maitonphi alone does my heart beat in devotion; Though adverse circumstances part us in this earthly life, our love remains green like the mountain pine. Beloved Ameishang, farewell on this mortal shore; in the spirit realm beyond, we shall part no more.

Chapter 7 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 7 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* leishat laa (noun): romantic song
  Example: Leishat laa sa.
* marongthei (noun): flowering shrub of fidelity
  Example: Marongthei reola.
* lungchan (noun): deep love, soul union
  Example: Ini lungchan malaihaosa.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Antiphonal romantic dialogue.
- Symbolism of botanical endurance.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? What plant symbolizes unyielding love in the ballad?
? How does the story conclude in traditional belief?

Chapter 8: Weaving Songs, Festive Banquets & Bedtime Chants

CHAPTER 8: WEAVING SONGS, FESTIVE BANQUETS & BEDTIME CHANTS

Summary: Back-strap loom weaving (Themsak), traditional shawls, and evening chants (Pet Laa).

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

O Tangkhul ngalanao yanglu yanglu, sak kasa kathemma themma; Haora chi yaron kachonna, Phangyai rah Tangkhul kashanna! Phungcham vana ratha apamva rarona, phanishida tarikhana vaotun; Nali ungthuilo, sami ngachiya, i ram kashamshiraro.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Behold the skilled Tangkhul maidens weaving traditional textiles with masterly artistry! The black-and-red Haora shawl is for valiant young men, and the Phangyai skirt for graceful women. Evening settles over the ridges of Phungcham; put aside your tools and find peaceful sleep.

Chapter 8 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 8 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* themsak laa (noun): weaving song
  Example: Themsak laa sa.
* haora (noun): traditional male shawl
  Example: Haora yaron kachon.
* phangyai (noun): traditional female skirt
  Example: Phangyai Tangkhul kashan.
* pet laa (noun): bedtime chant
  Example: Pet laa sa.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Textile terminology and designators.
- Evening benedictory phrasing.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? What is Haora and who wears it?
? What is Phangyai and what colors define it?

Comprehensive Vocabulary Glossary

COMPREHENSIVE BOOK GLOSSARY (TUIWON SHIYAN):

hokharai [noun]: invocation shout
kazingkum [noun]: spring season
sampheirok [noun]: spring songbird
thingreikhangava [noun]: carrying the monument tree
chaklen [noun]: augury bird
chumrei [noun]: grain barn
pheishon [noun]: ceremonial hornbill dance
arang [noun]: hornbill
mafathing [noun]: Phoebe hainesiana timber tree
yarra laa [noun]: youth festival song
longthing [noun]: communal firewood
meishum [noun]: morung fireplace
siluisa [noun]: buffalo meat for terrace workers
seihom [noun]: cattle herding
makreira [noun]: fermented rice beverage
ral laa [noun]: war song, victory chant
kharing [adj]: alive, captive
mahon [noun]: battle shout
leishat laa [noun]: romantic song
marongthei [noun]: flowering shrub of fidelity
lungchan [noun]: deep love, soul union
themsak laa [noun]: weaving song
haora [noun]: traditional male shawl
phangyai [noun]: traditional female skirt
pet laa [noun]: bedtime chant

Colophon & Archival Preservation Notice

TANGKHUL LANGUAGE LIBRARY DIGITAL PRESERVATION EDITION

Book ID: BK-LIT-002
Title: Folk Songs of The Tangkhul
Publisher: Directorate for Development of Tribals & Backward Classes, Manipur
Publication Year: 1987
Dialect Variety: Standard Tangkhul
Total Digital Pages: 22
Total Chapters: 8
Total Words Indexed: 598

Digitally preserved for mother-tongue education, linguistic research,
and cultural preservation. Verified by Tangkhul Language Preservation Project.